CONF42

From Self-Service to Safe Autonomy

The Authority Shift

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Decide

Authorize

Execute

At 2:14 a.m., the agent wanted to roll back production

Eight minutes after a deployment, the agent saw trouble and proposed a rollback. No person had asked for it.

P99 latency

+220%

Response time jumped sharply after the deployment.

Error rate

1.8% to 7.4%

Many more requests started failing.

Agent confidence

96%

The agent believed the deployment was the cause.

The question was not, can we roll back? It was, should the agent be allowed to decide this on its own?

Being right about the problem is not the same as having the authority to act.

The platform contract has changed

Self-service was built for people. Agents now create their own intent.

Before: self-service

A person decides what to do.

The platform checks one question: Can I do this?

Permissions were enough, because a person stood behind every request.

Now: agents create intent

An agent decides what to do.

The platform must also ask: Should this be decided at all, by this agent, right now?

Evidence, scope, and timing now matter.

Decision

What should happen now

Authority

Who or what may approve it, inside which limits

Execution

The verified action and its evidence

Execution checks are still needed. They are no longer enough on their own.

Authority is a short lease, not a permanent pass

A lease has a scope, conditions, and an expiry. It can be taken back at any time.

What the lease says

Who and what: This agent, this action, this service only.

Conditions: Fresh evidence and healthy dependencies.

How long: Short expiry, one action only, revocable in one step.

Why it matters

Same agent. Same tool.

Different situation,
different authority.

When the situation changes, the permission changes with it.

Authority is granted for a moment and a purpose, not forever.

Four steps between a proposal and an action

Each step is a place where the platform can pause, limit, or stop the action.

1. Propose

The agent states what it wants to do, and why.

2. Adjudicate

The platform checks policy, scope, conflicts, and risk.

3. Commit

The situation is checked again, right before acting.

4. Verify

Did the action actually help the customer?

State can change between the check and the action. That is why Commit checks again.

A successful tool call is not proof that the problem is fixed.

The first explanation might be wrong

High confidence is not the same as being right. Test the explanation before acting on it.

Other possible causes

Database under heavy load

A regional network issue

A change in the mix of traffic

Evidence that helps decide

Compare the new and old versions side by side

Look at the exact path that slowed down

Check a similar service that did not change

Ask: what evidence would show that the agent's explanation is wrong?

The bigger the impact of being wrong, the stronger the evidence must be.

A fix for one service can hurt the whole system

Judge an action by its effect on the whole system, not just one service.

The cascade

Service A: Rolls back and looks better alone

Shared database: Extra load from more retries

Services B and C: Slow down. The incident has moved

Recovery is owned at the system level.

Two agents, one system

Release agent: Rolls back while errors rise

Capacity agent: Scales at the same time

Together: They swing the system back and forth

A lock, a required pause, and the platform decides who goes first.

Locally safe is not the same as globally safe. Coordination is a platform job.

Agents earn authority, step by step

Moving up a step is a leadership decision, based on reviewed results.

1 Observe

Watch and report only. No action.

2 Recommend

Suggest an action. A person decides.

3 Act Within Bounds

Act inside clear, pre-agreed limits.

4 Act and Report

Act at once in urgent, reversible cases, then report.

Every promotion leaves a record. Authority is earned, never assumed.

Six checks before an agent acts

If any check fails, the action is narrowed, escalated, or stopped.

Evidence

Is it fresh and strong?

Confidence

How sure is the agent, and is that enough?

Blast radius

What else could this affect?

Reversibility

Can we undo it quickly?

Ownership

Who owns this service and this decision?

Time window

Is now the right time to act?

Every check leaves an Intent Record: who decided, what was decided, why, and when.

If you cannot answer who did it and when you knew, you have an authority problem.

Same recommendation. Different authority.

Live demo: only the situation changes. The recommendation stays the same.

ALLOW

Bounded lease

Fresh evidence, one service, healthy, reversible, no conflict.

The action goes ahead, inside a short lease.

ESCALATE

A person reviews

Something is unknown, or another agent is already acting.

A person reviews before anything runs.

DENY

Does not run

Evidence is stale, or the impact is too wide.

The action does not run in this state.

The state changed, so the authority changed.

Who owns the authority, and who owns the result?

Oversight means owning the delegation, not approving every click.

Platform team

Agent identity, policy, safe execution, and the ability to revoke access at any time.

Service owners

Evidence, safety limits, and checking that recovery actually worked.

Leaders and risk owners

How much authority to delegate, when to escalate, and who answers for the outcome.

The executive decisions

Set the tiers | **Set the evidence standard** | **Set the expiry** | **Set the escalation rule**

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Can your platform explain why it is saying YES?

The harder question

Self-service asked: Can I do this?

Safe autonomy asks: Should I be allowed to decide that this needs to be done?

Answer it in advance, in the platform, with a record.

Thank you

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